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STAYING AT THE TOP

In 2010, we faced three of the toughest assignments in international cricket and to maintain our number-one position we needed to do well in all of them. We had to play South Africa at home in February–March, Australia at home in October and New Zealand at home in November, before finally travelling to South Africa in December.

Before all these, however, we went to Bangladesh for a two-Test series in January 2010. While many feel Bangladesh are a pushover, they have surprised many a good side in the past and you underestimate them at your peril. This was evident in the first Test at Chittagong, which started on 17 January, where we were reduced to 209–8 in the first innings. The crowd was behind the local team and batting was a serious challenge against an inspired bowling attack, with Shahadat Hossain and Shakib-Al-Hasan both finally taking five wickets. Every wicket was greeted with a loud cheer and every boundary with pin-drop silence.

It was interesting to bat in front of such a partisan crowd. I scored 105 not out and we somehow managed to post a score of 243. Our bowlers did well to restrict Bangladesh in their first innings to one run less than our total, then Gambhir scored a century in our second innings, helping us to 413. Despite a century from Mushfiqur Rahim, the 415-run target proved too much for Bangladesh and we ended up winning by 113 runs.

In the second Test at Dhaka a few days later, where it was hot and sultry after the haze and chill in Chittagong, our fast bowlers again delivered in difficult conditions, with Zaheer bowling at his best in the second innings, getting an incredible amount of reverse swing to take